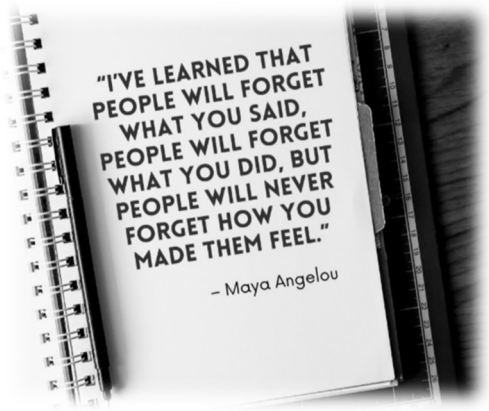
Leadership Tool: Delivering Positive Feedback

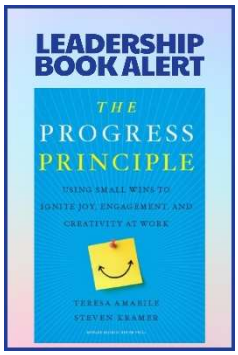
A great deal of time and energy go into developing effective leaders. It is complex because humans are complex. However, there is a leadership tool that is free, easy to use, applies to everyone and leaders have an unlimited supply that, if used, leaves those they are leading more motivated, engaged, and more productive. Additionally, those who use this tool are ranked as more effective leaders, by those they lead. It seems like both a simple decision to use it but also a necessity for the role of leadership. Yet the research on feedback suggests leaders fall short, time and time again, when it comes to delivering positive feedback. In fact, research suggests that managers dislike giving positive feedback even more than negative feedback (Zenger, J., & Folkman, 2017).



Positive feedback is critical for effective leadership, but unfortunately is often overlooked by leaders. Whether it is finding time, not knowing how to deliver positive feedback, or the belief that "a paycheck is the thanks an employee gets for doing their job," the truth is, leaders are just not using this tool effectively. This article looks to emphasize the importance of this leadership tool and provide reasons why it is important and offer some unique ways for leaders to provide positive feedback.

Let's Start with Why

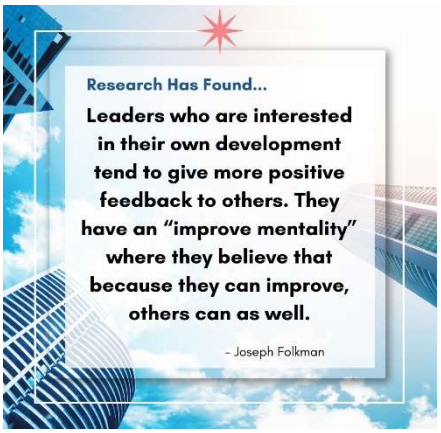
Offering positive feedback is a fundamental responsibility of effective leaders that generates numerous benefits for the individual receiving the feedback, the leader giving the feedback, and the organization. One of the main ways positive feedback is such a powerful tool is by helping to establish and reinforce desired behaviors and values. At the individual level, positive feedback helps set clear expectations for employees. The behaviors and values that get reinforced through positive feedback have a greater likelihood of being repeated by the individual getting the feedback. If the feedback is given publicly, then others will also be made aware of what is valued by the leader. If these behaviors and values are consistently reinforced, through positive feedback given by leaders in different areas of the organization, then collectively they become the most prized behaviors or values, establishing the culture of an organization.



Another benefit of positive feedback is the impact it has on motivation and engagement. Research has pointed out the benefits of positive feedback on several work-related attributes, including those in a great book called, "*The Progress Principle: Using small wins to ignite joy, engagement and creativity at work*" by researchers Amabile & Kramer. In their book the authors discuss the impact that positive feedback can have on innovation, independence, and a willingness to improve on established processes (Amabile & Kramer, 2011), all which are connected to motivation and engagement. Finally, "40% of employed Americans say they'd put more energy into their work if they were recognized more often" (Novak, 2016). By offering positive feedback, leaders

contribute to higher levels of motivation and engagement in others, ultimately leading to overall organizational success by driving performance and productivity.

Finally, positive feedback impacts the culture of teams and organizations. Leaders who utilize this tool to strengthen relationships and trust within their teams, create a culture for open communication and collaboration (Zenger, J., & Folkman, 2017). The goodwill and rapport created from genuine feedback fosters a supportive and cohesive work culture. Additionally, when team members feel valued and respected, by acknowledging their efforts, it leads to increased loyalty and commitment by individuals for both the team and its objectives. Finally, positive feedback cultivates a culture of continues improvement, learning, and growth because they are more receptive to constructive feedback when they feel supported and appreciated by their leaders. Ultimately, positive feedback empowers individuals to continue to learn and contribute while positioning the team for increased organizational success.



Best Practices: Giving Positive Feedback

With all the benefits of delivering positive feedback, it is important that leaders prioritize this activity in their leadership practices. However, as with any tool, there are some essential elements of delivering this type of feedback that need to be practiced to maximize its benefits. The following is a set of best practices that leaders should consider incorporating into the delivering positive feedback to their team.

- **Specific and Detailed Feedback**: One important best practice, when providing positive feedback, is to ensure that the feedback is both specific and detailed. Take time to highlight the employee's specific positive behavior, the value that they demonstrated or their achievement. This allows the employee to better understand exactly what the leader appreciates and provides them with a roadmap for what values and actions to replicate moving forward. Additionally, when the feedback is specific and detailed it also provides others on the team with clarity on what they should aim to do in the future.

- **Sincere Feedback**: Tied to the previous best practice is a need for leaders to provide sincere and authentic feedback. In addition to specific feedback, leaders should tie the feedback back to the impact it had on the individual, leader, or the team. If the feedback appears to be insincere or generic, it will decrease the positive benefits it normally would have on the employee. It is important for leaders to both be specific about the behaviors of the employee and sincere about how those actions impacted the organization.

- **Timely Feedback**: One of the major issues with performance reviews is that the process often happens long after the employee's desired actions. To maximize positive feedback, the feedback needs to occur promptly after the leader observes exceptional performance. This timely feedback allows the employee to connect their actions to the positive

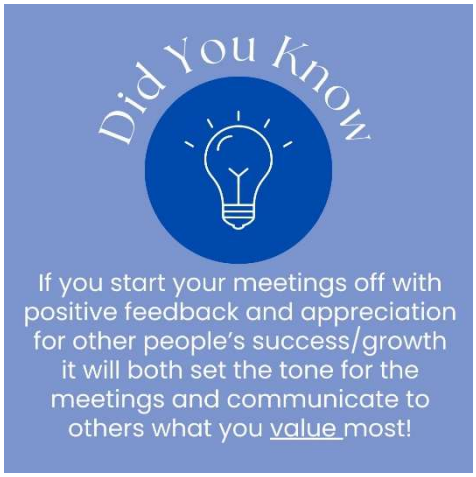
outcomes they achieved. While positive feedback should happen during processes like performance reviews, it is also important to recognize that the impact of positive feedback on the employee diminishes over time.

- **Frequency of the Feedback**: One area that leaders often question when utilizing this tool is, "how often should I deliver positive feedback?" Of course, to correspond with the best practices above, this will depend. Research has suggested that when building an extraordinary culture for teams, the optimal ratio for high-performing teams is approximately 5:1, with five positive feedback instances for every one negative feedback instance (Zenger & Folkman, 2013). This would certainly suggest that a leader needs to deliver an abundance of positive feedback to create an environment of support and appreciation. It is important, to be an effective leader, that daily you make it part of your habits to look for opportunities to provide positive feedback to those on your team or in the organization.

- **Unique to the Individual**: The final best practice is to deliver positive feedback in a manner that considers the individual's preferences and needs. By being able to adapt to different communication styles, the leader will enhance the impact the positive feedback has on the employee. Additionally, leaders should be mindful of potential cultural differences that can influence the perception and interpretation of positive feedback. Cultural norms and values regarding praise and recognition may vary, and leaders should be sensitive to these differences to ensure that positive feedback is well-received and aligned with cultural expectations. These extra considerations should not get in the way of effective leaders utilizing such a powerful tool. Instead, this is an opportunity to get to know their employees to ensure they are getting the most out of the feedback they are giving.

Unique Ways to Offer Positive Feedback

The more ways a leader has to offer positive feedback, the more likely they are to utilize this leadership tool to have an impact on employees, teams, and the organization. The following is a list of different methods of delivery that effective leaders can reference when putting together a holistic plan to use positive reinforcement. It is important that effective leaders remember the best practices above when combining different methods. While providing positive feedback is critical to a leader's success, it is only impactful when it is specific, authentic, and works with the preferences of the individual. Providing positive feedback in unique and creative ways can significantly enhance its impact on employees' motivation and engagement. By utilizing approaches from the following list leaders can create memorable and meaningful feedback experiences that contribute to a positive work environment.



Traditional Approach – The traditional approach (most often used by leaders) is finding opportunities throughout the day to both identify employee success and making a point to comment on this success. This can be in an impromptu interaction with the employee, or more publicly in team meetings, company-wide announcements, or recognition events to acknowledge and appreciate employees' accomplishments. Getting in the habit of continually bringing positive feedback and appreciation to these events is what the most effective leaders do to motivate their employees and brand themselves as a leader who appreciates others.

Handwritten Notes – While this might be more in line with the traditional approach, it is done at a significantly lower rate than any of the other traditional approaches mentioned above. Due to the decline in leaders writing handwritten correspondence in favor of an email, when employees receive a handwritten note, it just means more. In addition to the scarcity of this positive feedback approach, it also communicates warmth and personal connection, making the feedback more meaningful. Ideally, leaders should consider writing one handwritten note every other day, as a last action before they leave work. This will not only encourage this form of feedback to occur more often, but it will also leave the leader in a mindset of gratitude.

Using Technology – While technology has increased the speed of work and the responsibilities of a leader, it has also made providing positive feedback easier and personalized. Leaders can utilize technology to create personalized video messages or digital presentations. This approach to delivering positive feedback adds a personal touch and allows for visual and auditory elements that enhance the impact and emotional resonance of the feedback. Additionally, incorporating gamification elements into positive feedback can make it more engaging and enjoyable. If done well, gamification elements, such as badges, levels, or leaderboards, can enhance motivation and drive positive behavior. Finally, leaders can create a system where employees earn virtual rewards or badges for their achievements, providing positive feedback in a fun and interactive way.

Positive Peer-to-Peer Feedback – If leaders are looking to spread a culture of positive feedback it is important to establish peer-to-peer positive feedback programs. This can be as simple as setting up time for employees to recognize each other (possible an opportunity to celebrate/acknowledge a peer at department meetings) or more elaborate recognition programs, where colleagues can submit positive feedback and the individual being recognized receives a more substantial reward. No matter what shape the peer-to-peer feedback takes, it is sure to foster a culture of mutual support and recognition.

Conclusion

It is important to balance positive feedback regularly without overwhelming employees. It is also critical that leaders remain fair and unbiased when delivering positive feedback. If positive feedback is perceived as disproportionately favoring certain individuals or groups, it can lead to feelings of resentment and demotivation among other employees. A simple method for addressing this is to keep track of who is getting positive feedback (especially when rewards are

involved). Additionally, leaders should make sure there are objective criteria for reward-based positive feedback, communicating it to all members of the team. Finally, positive feedback is critical, but a lack of constructive feedback can hinder growth. Being able to communicate effectively utilizing both positive and constructive feedback is essential for leaders. Utilizing both the different methods of providing positive feedback above and the best practices to increase impact, leaders will be better able to utilize this tool to engage employees, strengthen their teams, and have a positive cultural influence on the organization.

References

Amabile, T., & Kramer, S. (2011). *The progress principle: Using small wins to ignite joy, engagement, and creativity at work*. Harvard Business Press.

Novak, D. (2016). Recognizing employees is the simplest way to improve morale. *Harvard Business Review*, *9*(2016), 2-4.

Zenger, J., & Folkman, J. (2013). The ideal praise-to-criticism ratio. *Harvard Business Review*, *15*.

Zenger, J., & Folkman, J. (2017). Why do so many managers avoid giving praise. *Harvard business review*, *2*.